

gbawriter V1.3

Full controls · Halim Jarrar

Create and edit TXT files on your Game Boy Advance. Save your writing directly to the SD card. Put TXT files in **/gbawriter** at the root of your SD card. Requires a compatible Supercard SD.

Hardware-unverified build: emulator and host tests are not proof of safe saving on a physical Supercard. Back up your SD card and use disposable documents first.

Installation

- A GBA-compatible system and **Supercard SD** using the inherited SuperFW-compatible SD driver. Other flashcarts and generic emulator save files are not supported storage backends.
- Copy gbawriter.gba to your flashcart and launch it through its usual ROM loader. The source build produces the ROM; published builds belong under this repository's Releases.
- Documents live only in **/gbawriter/** on the SD card. The app attempts to create the directory when New/Load is first selected. An SD/directory error is displayed instead of discarding text.
- Menu and control instructions do not probe SD at boot. Choosing New/Load shows CHECKING SD...; an absent/incompatible card can take a substantial driver timeout to report an error. Emulator menu/help operation does not imply SD access works.
- Back up the SD card before testing. Never remove the card or power off while SAVING is displayed.

Diary and file workflow

New File is selected at startup. Press A to choose a date, then A to create and edit. The preset is exactly one calendar day after the chronologically latest valid diary filename, including month/year/leap-year transitions. Filenames use **DDMMYYYY.txt**; raw alphabetical order is not used to choose the latest date.

If no dated documents exist, the manual starting date is **10 July 2026**. This is an editable preset, not a real-time clock. In the date picker, Up/Down selects Day/Month/Year; Left decrements and Right increments the field; A creates; B returns. Invalid day combinations are clamped. Supported years are 1–9999. At the upper calendar boundary there is no representable next day: the picker retains the latest date, and creation still refuses a collision.

New File never overwrites an existing name, including case-only .TXT differences. A collision shows FILE ALREADY EXISTS and returns to the unchanged proposed date after acknowledgment. It does not add suffixes or truncate the original.

Load File lists .txt files in /gbawriter/: valid diary dates newest first, then other names alphabetically (ASCII case-insensitive). Up/Down selects; A opens; B returns. The display shows six entries at a time; the storage index rescans in bounded 32-entry batches, so the directory is not limited to 32 files. Longer directories take longer to rescan. There are no delete, rename, duplicate, or overwrite-from-menu actions.

Controller layout

Main-menu **SELECT** opens controls and **START** opens credits; **B** returns from either. The adjacent bottom hints read exactly Select: Controls and Start: Credits. Credits always open on the personal first page: Made by Halim Jarrar, (C) 2026, halim-jarrar.de, and monday@halim-jarrar.de, with no third-party credit mixed into that page. Left/Right cycles the two Credits pages; B returns from either. The second page credits the SuperFW software font renderer, UNSCII fonts (viznut.fi/unsicii, inherited source marked GPL), and Unifont-derived Hangul blocks. Font notices remain in the source.

The suite home screen reads gbawriter V1.3 and files: /gbawriter, with NEW FILE first/default and LOAD FILE second. The UI label is independent of the release tag.

Menu interface text, help section headings and navigation hints use the 5x7 font from gbamp3 (black; key hints grey); the blue Butano font draws only the > cursor on the menu, date fields and file list. Numeric date values, text filenames, saving indications, controls body text and credits content retain the SuperFW-based writing font. Editor typography and status positions are unchanged.

Hold a direction, then press **B / A / R** to choose its **first / second / third** letter. Lowercase is the default.

Direction	Normal: B / A / R	Hold L: B / A / R
Up	a / b / c	d / e / f
Right	h / i / j	k / l / m
Down	n / o / p	q / r / s
Left	t / u / w	x / y / z

L is held, never toggled. Diagonals are not letter groups.

- Keep Right held and press R twice: the first j becomes **g**.
- Keep Left held and press R twice: the first w becomes **v**.
- Release the group between presses to type literal jj or ww. These transformations depend on the same continuous hold, **not timing**, and never substitute unrelated text.
- **A alone:** space. **B alone:** backspace one UTF-8 codepoint; no effect at the beginning. Hold either button alone to repeat: one immediate edit, first repeat after **24 frames**, then every **5 frames**, exactly matching START navigation. Adding any other button cancels edit repeat; releasing a chord's modifier does not start it. Release A/B and press it alone again to rearm. Letter/SELECT/save chords remain press-only.
- **START released alone:** newline. Holding it does not insert immediately.

Shift and Caps

From normal case, **release a short isolated R press to arm one-shot Shift**. Hold **R alone continuously for 48 frames** (twice the initial A-repeat delay; about 0.8 seconds at 60 Hz) to enable **Caps while still held**, once per hold. Any other button before the threshold cancels that hold; releasing the companion cannot restart it. Release R and start a fresh solo hold.

With **Shift or Caps already active**, another isolated R press—short or long—**clears the mode on release**. It cannot arm Shift or Caps again during the same hold. Shift applies to the next successfully inserted alphabetic character; digits, spaces and punctuation do not consume it.

With Caps on, one isolated R press/release turns Caps off without arming Shift. R inside a direction group remains the third-letter key and cannot toggle Caps. Shift/Caps applies to the international letters below; ß stays ß, never two letters. Rejected capacity-limited edits do not consume Shift. A failed save preserves Shift/Caps as well as the document.

The bottom status bar reads **filename → active letter group → Shift/Caps**. The filename starts at x=8 (128-pixel slot), the group at x=144 (32-pixel slot), and Shift/Caps at x=184 (48-pixel slot): hold Up to see abc, or ABC with Shift/Caps; all normal and held-L groups follow the same rule. Release the direction to clear it; diagonals and START navigation show no letter group. * marks unsaved changes. Transient messages occupy only the filename slot, leaving capitalization and group visible.

START commands

Hold START, then:

Button	Action
Left / Right	Move caret one UTF-8 codepoint
Up / Down	Move to the closest horizontal position in the adjacent visual row
L / R	Previous / next viewport page, maintaining a valid caret
A	Save the current file
B	Save, then return to the main menu only on success
SELECT	Toggle the bottom status bar / full-screen editor

Navigation repeats while held. Releasing START after a recognized command **does not add a newline**, even when saving fails. A save failure opens a clear error message and returns to the editor with text retained after acknowledgment. There is no discard shortcut or autosave.

SELECT: one provisional character

Press SELECT alone to insert **.** **immediately**. Keep SELECT held to change **that same character**; release to keep it. Exception: SELECT after an eligible continuously held letter chord converts the existing letter instead (see International letters). Cycling never appends additional characters.

While SELECT is held	Cycle
Up	. → 1 → 2 → 3 → 4 → 5 → 6 → 7 → 8 → 9 → 0 → 1 ...
Down	. → 0 → 9 → 8 → 7 → 6 → 5 → 4 → 3 → 2 → 1 → 0 ...
R, without a direction	. → , → ' → " → : → ! → ? → .
L, without a completed letter chord	Exact reverse common-punctuation cycle
Right	. → (→) → / → ; → @ → # → % → & → _ → + → = → - → .
Left	Exact reverse additional-symbol cycle

A completed letter chord takes priority over intermediate directional/punctuation changes. For example SELECT, then Up, then L, then A changes the same provisional **.** to 1 and then to é, not three characters. A complete L-layer chord similarly overrides the temporary SELECT+L punctuation step. Unsupported accent families leave the provisional glyph unchanged. **START+SELECT toggles the status bar in the editor only**, in either press order. It cancels only a newly inserted SELECT provisional character, restoring the original caret and dirty state. A converted existing letter stays accented; it is not deleted. The chord never types, saves, or adds a newline. It toggles once per hold and suppresses commands until both START and SELECT are released; other held buttons do not prevent rearming.

International letters

Accents work in either order: hold SELECT, then enter the normal letter combination; or enter a letter and keep its **exact single D-pad direction, L if used, and producing B/A/R button continuously held**, then press SELECT. That same letter changes to its first accented variant, keeping its case, without adding a period or another letter. There is no time limit, but releasing or changing the combination ends eligibility. Other extra buttons disqualify this letter-first gesture; diagonals are not letter groups. A letter with no accent variants stays unchanged in the letter-first order.

Example: hold L+UP and press A to type e; keep L+UP+A held and press SELECT to turn that same e into é. In the other order, hold SELECT, then L+UP and press A to produce é as one character. The held-L groups work in both orders too.

While SELECT and the same group remain held, **release and press the final B/A/R selector again** to cycle in the exact order below. Keep the direction and L layer (if used) held during cycling. Release SELECT to keep the current result. The letter-first result keeps the original letter's lowercase/Shift/Caps case, even after one-shot Shift was consumed.

Family	Lowercase cycle	Uppercase equivalents
A	á â ã ä å æ	Á Â Ã Ä Å Æ
C	ç ċ ċ	Ç Ć Ć
E	é è ê ë	É Ê Ë Ì
I	í î ï ð	Í Î Ï ð
N	ñ ñ	Ñ Ñ
O	ó ô õ ö ø œ	Ó Ô Õ Ö Ø Æ
S	ß š š	ß Š Š
U	ü ú û û	Ü Ú Û Ü
Y	ý ŷ	Ý Ÿ
Z	ž ž ž	Ž Ž Ž

E/S/Y/Z use the held L layer; N/O/U are unmodified groups. Cycles wrap back to the first alternate. All 77 distinct required lowercase/uppercase glyphs are verified against the real font packs and renderer, including even/odd pixel addressing. Main-menu **SELECT** opens 20 control pages; Left/Right changes page; B returns. Help strings are checked for glyph coverage and screen width.

Storage and attribution

Files have no size limit: they stay on the SD card and only changes use RAM. Up to 64 KiB of typed text can be unsaved at once; when the bar shows BUFFER FULL - SAVE, save to continue (the text is kept). Saving a large file takes longer. Saves change only the opened TXT file; no permanent .sav or settings file is used. Temporary .gwt, .gwb and .gwi recovery files may remain after interrupted or failed saves. Do not delete them on the original card: back up the card and consult the README recovery instructions. There is no undo/redo, autosave or discard shortcut.

Made by Halim Jarrar · (C) 2026 · halim-jarrar.de · monday@halim-jarrar.de. Based on GBARender, SuperFW, Butano, FatFS and miniz; credits and font/vendor notices remain in the source. Fonts: SuperFW software font renderer; UNSCII fonts (viznut.fi/unsicii, inherited source marked GPL); Unifont-derived Hangul blocks. Original font notices remain in references/superfw/res/fonts. Application source: GNU GPL v3. See LICENSE and README for full attribution.